

## Chapter 60: Same Grave

Being calm in her mind didn't mean being calm in reality. Chu Qingqiu and Ning Fuyi were currently falling with sand and debris, the dust scattering in the darkness, making it impossible to open their eyes.

Just as they were about to hit the ground, the divine sword finally roared out from the prayer bead, enlarging as it wrapped around her waist, barely allowing her to stand steadily on the ground instead of landing ungracefully on all fours.

"Chu Qingqiu!" She immediately looked up and called out, only to see a white silk ribbon piercing through the sand, carrying a person down to land. White Lin swept away the dust on the ground like rising clouds and mist.

Ning Fuyi's anxious heart slowly settled. She spat out the sand in her mouth and pressed down on the divine sword that was frantically rubbing against her arm.

"Xiangsi<sup>1</sup>, stop fooling around." She said while wiping her lips, then used the divine sword's light to look around.

She and Chu Qingqiu had fallen into a cramped stone chamber. The ground was covered with accumulated sand, everywhere showing the antiquity of weathering. Occasionally there were uneven places on the ground - Ning Fuyi pushed at them with her toe and uncovered two human leg bones.

"What kind of ghostly place is this?" Ning Fuyi frowned.

That painting indeed had tricks hidden within it - it was actually a mechanism to open the underground chamber. When Qiu Yi was shouting in her mind earlier, the pagoda in the painting had pierced straight into Chi Du's heart with a terrifying appearance as if it were real. The next moment, the entire study turned upside down, and when they opened their eyes again, they had already fallen to this place.

"It seems to be a tomb." Chu Qingqiu answered. She walked around the scattered bones on the ground and tapped the brick wall above with her White Bone weapon.

When they fell earlier, the top was still open, but now it had become a thick wall.

"We've been tricked! That empress is indeed a fake." Ning Fuyi shook her head. "But where exactly did we expose ourselves as people from the immortal sects?"

This time even Chu Qingqiu couldn't figure it out: "This venerable was careless, never expecting the other party would know our identities. It seems this person is very profound and mysterious."

"Qiu Yi, how are things on your end?" Ning Fuyi said in her mind. "If you don't have time to answer, you don't need to."

"Bah! Still talking nonsense when death is near!" Qiu Yi scolded with a trembling voice, then said, "She hasn't done anything to me, just tied me to the bedpost. I can't break free."

"She actually didn't make a move against you..." Ning Fuyi suddenly had a flash of inspiration. "Qiu Yi, are you certain you've never seen that empress before?"

"Never." Qiu Yi answered.

This shouldn't be the case. Both she and Chu Qingqiu had changed their appearances and concealed their auras. Even if they dug Ning Changfeng out of the ground, he wouldn't recognize them. How could a complete stranger see through their identities?

The problem could only lie with Qiu Yi. That empress must have known Qiu Yi's identity, which allowed her to deduce the others'.

She shared her speculation with Chu Qingqiu, who didn't say anything but instructed Qiu Yi not to reveal the secret that she could hear their conversation.

"You make sense. But now is not the time to dwell on how she knew our identities. We need to understand why she didn't directly try to take our lives, but instead brought us underground." Chu Qingqiu said softly.

"And she didn't kill Qiu Yi either. Besides the possibility that they might know each other, perhaps she never intended to take our lives in the first place."

"Then we might need to first figure out whose tomb this actually is." Ning Fuyi said. She walked along the dirty walls in a circle and successfully discovered a passage hidden in the shadows. However, the passage was really too small - it didn't seem to be made for people to crawl through.

Even Ping An would probably get his belly stuck if he came.

"Xiangsi, you go." Ning Fuyi called the divine sword over and pointed at the opening. The sword began diligently digging.

"This imperial palace is built on top of an underground palace - that's indeed excellent feng shui<sup>2</sup>. I wonder what the emperors who lived here for generations would think if they knew." Ning Fuyi said while lying on the ground. "No wonder I felt this place was eerie."

Xiangsi quickly dug out a path that people could walk through. Ning Fuyi was about to step inside when her sleeve suddenly tightened - Chu Qingqiu had grabbed it.

"I'll go first." Chu Qingqiu said, then in a flash, she walked ahead of Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi curved her lips and followed behind her with peace of mind.

This passage wasn't long. After walking for just a while, they could see the exit. The divine sword went ahead first, using its body to illuminate the scene outside the exit. However, just as they were about to step out, Chu Qingqiu's body suddenly retreated, accidentally colliding into Ning Fuyi's embrace.

Before Ning Fuyi could think much, her gaze went past Chu Qingqiu's arm and came face to face with a huge iron-green human face.

Chu Qingqiu's body was still rigid in her arms, not daring to move forward. So Ning Fuyi reached out and pushed that thing away, laughing: "Venerable, it's a bronze statue."

Only when the heavy bronze figure hit the ground did Chu Qingqiu's tense body relax, letting out a long breath.

This was difficult for Chu Qingqiu - afraid of ghosts yet always diving into piles of them. Ning Fuyi wanted to laugh but still restrained her amusement. Her body nimbly slipped under Chu Qingqiu's arm: "Never mind, I'll go in front."

She stepped over the bronze statue, and before her appeared a vast space. Dozens of bronze figures were arranged in two mighty rows, all standing steadily facing the same direction, each holding weapons in their hands with different expressions - from afar they looked like real people.

"Burial goods." Ning Fuyi said softly. She carefully moved between the two rows of bronze figures, looking down at the weapons in their hands. She was surprised to discover that those weapons weren't cast from bronze, but were actual divine weapons.

There were as many divine weapons as there were bronze figures here.

"This underground palace..." Ning Fuyi said half a sentence before Chu Qingqiu took over.

"Buries a god." Chu Qingqiu said.

With her back to Chu Qingqiu, Ning Fuyi suddenly felt someone patting her shoulder. She was about to turn around to see what was wrong when she heard Chu Qingqiu's suddenly tense voice: "Ning Fuyi, don't turn around!"

Ning Fuyi immediately turned her head back, followed by the sound of wind cutting past her ear. Something crashed to the ground, splashing cold liquid all over her back. Then Chu Qingqiu brushed past her, grabbed her hand, and pulled her past those rows of bronze figures.

The bronze figures that had been motionless just moments ago were now all coming to life, stretching and moving their necks like real people who had stood too long and had sore backs. Then they all rushed forward, the divine weapons in their hands all taking effect, fiercely slashing at the two women.

"Xiangsi!" Ning Fuyi shouted loudly. The divine sword spun and fell into her hand. Pink light flashed, and the two bronze figures in front lost their heads, spraying crimson blood at Ning Fuyi.

However, losing their heads seemed to have no effect on them. Two swords carrying divine power stabbed straight at Ning Fuyi's heart. Ning Fuyi gritted her teeth and swung Xiangsi to cut off the ancient swords. The moment the blade flew out, Ning Fuyi's tiger's mouth<sup>3</sup> felt as if it had been shattered, the pain making her vision go black.

This was the power of the god race. Even just a few bronze figures were this difficult to deal with. Ning Fuyi thought angrily, especially since her immortal power was currently suppressed by more than half - she could basically only rely on close combat.

Chu Qingqiu beside her was somewhat better off, but not by much. Soon the ground was piled with shattered bronze corpses and divine weapons, and both their hands could barely be lifted anymore.

"Doesn't this damn place have an exit?!" Ning Fuyi shouted loudly. They had already run to the end of the corridor, where there was a pitch-black wall. Ning Fuyi had tried chiseling it with Xiangsi earlier and nearly had her wrist knocked off.

"They're all sealed shut - no exits, no mechanisms." Chu Qingqiu's voice was trembling slightly. She lowered her arms and kicked a bronze figure flying with her foot.

While she and Chu Qingqiu were entangled in combat with the bronze figures, she kept feeling around on the walls with one hand, trying to find anything that seemed wrong. But no matter how she searched, it was just smooth walls on three sides, and even the ground couldn't be dug through anymore.

It was as if they weren't in a tomb chamber, but trapped in a cramped bronze coffin.

Wait, a coffin? Ning Fuyi's mind stirred. She suddenly stepped on Xiangsi, using the sword to fly into the air, stretching her arms to feel around the ceiling. After feeling all around, she finally found a pull ring in the center.

With the situation urgent, she didn't care about anything else and pulled hard. The top suddenly made grinding sounds of giant stones colliding, then the entire ceiling flipped over along a line.

"Chu Qingqiu!" Seeing the chaos below gradually consuming everything, Ning Fuyi urgently shouted. Just as the ceiling completely flipped, Chu Qingqiu's figure passed through the gap and landed steadily.

Her forehead was covered with sweat, slightly out of breath, using her white jade staff to support her body as she looked around.

"Another tomb chamber." She said lightly. "The tomb chambers in this place are actually layered one on top of another."

"If nothing unexpected happens, the highest one should be the main burial chamber." Ning Fuyi said, her hands red from the earlier shock. She shook her wrists.

"Even in death they want to step on others. This god wasn't exactly a compassionate deity." Ning Fuyi blew on her wrists. "I wonder if that imposter outside hates him or loves him."

Chu Qingqiu neither agreed nor disagreed.

They caught their breath, then began studying the tomb chamber they were now in. This place was several times larger than the previous one. On the spacious elevated platform were seven coffins arranged in the pattern of the Big Dipper<sup>4</sup>, with nothing else besides them.

"The coffins here are larger than ordinary ones." Chu Qingqiu said. She stared at the jade-white coffins, discovering the delicate patterns on them. "These patterns - they're for husband and wife joint burial coffins."

"Living together under the same quilt, dying in the same grave<sup>5</sup>. Could it be that this tomb owner was a devoted lover?" Ning Fuyi guessed.

"Unlikely." Chu Qingqiu shook her head. "It's more like using husband and wife burials to create a Seven Star Formation<sup>6</sup>, suppressing miasma and gathering yin souls."

Just as she finished speaking, suddenly a clear gong sound came from the distance. Both of their bodies trembled simultaneously. After a while came the second sound, getting louder and closer.

Accompanied by the sound of iron chains scraping against the ground, there was a terrifying sense of approaching death that made even Ning Fuyi's scalp tingle.

"Venerable, there are words on this." Ning Fuyi quickened her speech. "Living together under furs, dying in the same grave<sup>7</sup>. The heartless shall perish, those who leave the grave shall die."

Chu Qingqiu immediately said "Quickly!" The two of them pulled at the heavy coffin lid with force, finally moving it halfway to reveal two pale human faces inside.

Indeed it was a man and a woman, embracing each other face to face. Reaching out to touch them - ice cold, without any human warmth.

"Forgive us. Once I get out, I'll definitely find a high monk to properly guide your souls to rest!" Ning Fuyi muttered quietly while pulling at their collars, dragging both people out together and placing them on the ground.

The gong sounded again, this time so close it seemed to be right beside their ears. Ning Fuyi's whole body broke out in goosebumps. She couldn't care about anything else - she quickly pushed Chu Qingqiu, and after Chu Qingqiu's body fell into the coffin, she also leaped in.

Just as they closed the lid, the sound of iron chains also stopped beside the coffin, then fell silent, a silence so deathly it was terrifying.

After a long while, someone bent their fingers and knocked twice on the coffin.

Two dong-dong sounds, and Ning Fuyi's scalp immediately tingled. She frantically thought about what other details they might have missed, then suddenly remembered they had indeed overlooked one detail.

"Chu Qingqiu." She thought in her mind.

Chu Qingqiu obviously realized it too. She was silent at first, then turned over in the narrow coffin, placing her hand on her waist.

Her soft arm applied gentle pressure, and her fragrant breath fell by Ning Fuyi's ear as the two faced each other and embraced tightly.

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### Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> **Xiangsi (相思)** - The name of Ning Fuyi's divine sword, literally meaning "mutual longing" or "lovesickness"

<sup>2</sup> **Feng shui (风水)** - Traditional Chinese practice of harmonizing with the environment and natural forces for auspicious placement of buildings and graves

<sup>3</sup> **Tiger's mouth (虎口)** - The web of skin between the thumb and index finger, a pressure point in traditional Chinese medicine

<sup>4</sup> **Big Dipper (北斗七星)** - Seven-star constellation important in Chinese astronomy and mythology, often used in formation patterns

<sup>5</sup> **Living together under the same quilt, dying in the same grave (生同衾，死同穴)** - Classical Chinese idiom expressing the ideal of devoted couples staying together in life and death

<sup>6</sup> **Seven Star Formation (七星阵)** - A mystical formation based on the Big Dipper constellation, commonly used in Chinese cultivation and folklore for various magical purposes

<sup>7</sup> **Living together under furs, dying in the same grave (生同裘，死同穴)** - Variation of the previous idiom, "fur" referring to shared bedding